Some "Vertical" Phonetic Effects in Catullus

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I *Introduction*

Kenneth Quinn, describing typical Catullan syntactic patterns, has written of "a use of repetition that becomes at times almost obsessive in intensity."[1] One may quibble, of course, with such psychologizing terminology, however apt the term "obsessive" may be for Catullus; but the fact remains that on a purely stylistic level, this lexical repetition is one of the most characteristic (and by now well-studied) features of Catullus' style.[2] In an important sense, repetition of words and phrases is merely a large-scale instance of Catullus' well-known fondness for phonetic repetition in general. The most familiar manifestation of this trait is of course alliteration, and Catullus' alliterative technique has itself been subjected to highly detailed scrutiny.[3] But there is more to phonetic repetition in Catullus than alliteration. Long before W. M. Clarke's conclusive demonstration of the importance of intentional end-rhyme in Vergil and Ovid (with less detailed indications for Catullus and other poets), Herescu's pioneering study of assonance and Elder's articles of the fifties and sixties had already pointed to the importance of end-rhyme in Catullus, especially in the polymetric poems,[4] and more recently, for example, we

1 *Catullus: The Poems*, 2nd ed. rev. (London and Basingstoke 1973) xxxii.

2 Among more recent studies, see, for example, Janine Évrard-Gillis, *La récurrence léxicale dans l'oeuvre de Catulle* (Paris 1976); Helmut Offermann, "Das Stilmittel der Wiederholung in Catulls kleinen Gedichten," *Museum Helveticum* 33 (1976) 234-47; Susana Reisz de Rivarola, *Poetische Äquivalenzen: Grundverfahren dichterischer Gestaltung bei Catull* (Amsterdam 1977), and the useful survey by Claudia Facchini Tosi, *La ripetizione lessicale nei poeti latini: Vent' anni di studio (1960-1980)* (Bologna 1983) 69-88.

3 The fundamental treatment remains that of Alessandro Ronconi, *Studi catulliani* (Brescia 1970, 2nd ed.) 11-86.

4 W.M. Clarke, "Intentional rhyme in Vergil and Ovid," *TAPA* 103 (1972) 49-77; N. Herescu, "L'assonance latine," *Lettres d' Humanité* 5 (1946) 132-48; and J.P. Elder, "Notes on some

have Giordano's study of assonance and rhyme (including end-rhyme) in the Catullan elegiac distich.[5]

But despite intensive study of familiar features like alliteration, and despite somewhat more limited attention to less well-known features like end-rhyme, the full range of Catullus' phonetic technique still remains to be uncovered. Here I wish to describe and analyze part of a hitherto unnoticed area of Catullus' phonetic technique, and one that incorporates features of both alliteration and end-rhyme—namely, repetitions of word-initial consonants at the ends (and sometimes also at the beginnings) of successive lines of verse. I restrict myself here to two such patterns involving the consonant *p-*, although the technique is clearly more general, as the preceding discussion has already implied.

II *Catullus 64.1-7*

Poem 64 begins as follows:

1) **Peliaco** quondam prognatae vertice **pin**us
dicuntur liquidas Neptuni **nasse per** undas
Phasidos ad fluctus et fines Aeeteos
cum lecti iuvenes, Argivae robo**ra pubis**,
auratam optantes Colchis avert**ere pellem**
ausi sunt vada salsa cita decurr**ere puppi**,
caerula verrentes abiegnis aequ**ora palmis**. (1-7)

The elaborate style of poem 64's opening sentence has been much discussed. Among the most interesting components of this rich texture are the reminiscences of the prologue of Ennius' *Medea Exul*, which I give for reference in (2):

2) Utinam ne in nemore **Pelio** securibus
caesae accidissent abiegnae ad terram trabes,
neve inde navis inchoandi exordium
coepisset quae nunc nominatur nomine
Argo, quia Argivi in ea delecti **viri**
vecti petebant pellem inauratam arietis
Colchis imperio regis Peliae per dolum;
nam numquam era errans mea domo efferret pedem
Medea animo aegro amore saevo saucia. (1-9)

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conscious and subconscious elements in Catullus' poetry," *HSCP* 60 (1951) 115, and "Catullus 1, his poetic creed, and Nepos," *HSCP* 71 (1966) 145.

5 Fausto Giordano, "Ricerche sulle assonanze e rime finali di parola nel distico catulliano," *Annali della Facoltà di Lettere e Filosofia della Univ. di Napoli* 24 (1981-82) 121-38. Eva H. Guggenheimer, "Acoustic symmetry in Catullus," *Dialectica* 24 (1970) 185-95 which partly concerns end-rhyme, to judge from secondary references to it, was unfortunately unavailable to me. It is curious (to say the least) that the 1980 "revised edition" of a popular handbook of Greek and Latin metrics continues to state categorically: "there is no evidence that rhyme was sought for itself by the Latin poets" (James W. Halporn, Martin Ostwald and Thomas G. Rosenmeyer, *The Meters of Greek and Latin Poetry* [Norman 1980, rev.] 71).

For the many features in the Catullus opening ultimately traceable to the Ennian passage, one may now refer to Arkins' detailed comparative study;[6] for our purposes, note especially certain resonances that are as much phonetic as they are lexical. Thus the first word *Peliaco* and the repeated *p*'s of 64.1 (***Peliaco** . . . **prognatae** . . . **pinus***), as well as the post-caesural alliterated figure ***Neptuni nasse*** in 64.2, immediately evoke not only the ***Pelio*** of Ennius' first line, but also, more generally, the alliterative technique Ennius shares with most other Archaic Latin writers.[7]

But apart from these more or less traditional alliterative figures in 64.1-2 (and elsewhere in the poem: e.g., ***prisci praecepta parentis*** [159] or ***cuncto concepit corpore flammam / funditus*** [92-93]), the extraordinary line-final "vertical" (so to speak) phonetic repetitions of 64.4-7 have gone almost entirely unnoticed. Picking up, as it were, the *p*-pattern introduced "horizontally" in the first line,[8] the sentence concludes with the four lines ending as in (3):

3)		
	pūbi(s)	4
	p(e)ll(e)m	5
	puppī	6
	p(a)lm(īs)	7

The phonetic parallelism is rendered all the more striking (or "perceptually prominent") by the fact that each two-syllable line-final *p*-initial word precedes a pause or syntactic break—a minor one at the end of line 5, directly preceding the main verb *ausi sunt*, and major ones for the other lines, concluding with the end of the sentence itself. The phonetic parallels themselves extend far beyond the identity of initial consonant: there is an intricate and extensive set of phonetic similarities and contrasts which are partly organized, descriptively speaking, in an interlocking fashion. Thus in lines 4 and 6, ending with:

pūbis	4
puppī	6

the phonetic sequences are nearly identical, with contrasts in voicing, vowel length, and gemination. Similarly, in lines 5 and 7, ending with:

pellem	5
palmīs	7

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6 Brian Arkins, "Tradition reshaped: Language and style in Euripides' *Medea* 1-19, Ennius' *Medea Exul* 1-9 and Catullus 64.1-30," *Ramus* 11 (1982) 116-33.

7 Although not noted by commentators, it seems to me significant that the brief reminiscence of this passage by Ovid (*Am.* 2.11.1-2: ***Prima** malas docuit, **mi**rantibus aequoris undis / Peliaco pinus vertice caesa vias*) makes use of the same Ennian technique, once again with a pointed use of a *p*-alliteration involving the (line-initial) word *Peliacus*; similarly, perhaps, the reminiscence in Propertius (3.22.11-12: ***tuque tuo Colchum propellas remige Phasin, / Peliacaeque trabis totum iter ipse legas***).

8 And, as Stephen Deitz points out to me, continued to some extent in lines two and three via *Neptuni ... per* (2) (with *per undas* as a virtual "phonological word," cf. below, note 11) and *Phasidos* (3).

the consonant sequence [p-l-m] is identical, again with a contrast in gemination for the second consonant, just as in *pūbis* and *puppī*.[9]

These parallels could of course be described in other ways, as for example according to the following scheme:

4)		
	[p - b]	4
	[p - m]	5
	[p - p]	6
	[p - m]	7

That is, each word contains two labial consonants, in the interlocking sequence [p-b], [p-m], [p-p], [p-m]; and still other phonetic patterns can be noted, such as the systematic progression of the final sounds *-is*, *-m*, *-t*, *-mīs*, in which *-mīs* forms a kind of inclusive coda for the whole series.

In addition to this striking *phonetic* organization, these four words are *semantically* related both to each other, and to the topic of the sentence: in themselves, the words *pubis* 'youth', *pellem* 'fleece', *puppi* 'ship' and *palmis* 'oar-blades' encapsulate, following the sequence of his narration, the essence of the story Catullus is evoking: who went, why they went, how they got there. The entire sequence, moreover, begins with the phrase *lecti iuvenes, Argivae robora pubis* (64.4)—a clear reminiscence of Ennius' *Argivi delecti viri*. But note that what Ennius' phrase introduces is the highly marked double alliterative sequence *viri vecti petebant pellem* (including a *p*-series with the word *pellem*), which encapsulates the story in precisely the same terms: the men *(Argivi . . . delecti viri)* on the ship *(vecti)* went after the fleece *(petebant pellem)*. Brian Arkins, in the study already referred to, has rightly observed that Catullus' alliterated *p*-figure in line 1 "serve[s] to emphasize what is being said by . . . linking words closely together," just as in Ennius, alliteration "in linking together particular sense units tends to underline their meaning,"[10] comparing, in Ennius, sequences like *nunc nominatur nomine* (4), *era errans* (8), or *animo aegro amore saevo saucia* (9). What is most remarkable, however, is that Catullus has in effect transformed Ennius' horizontal sense-linked double figure *viri vecti petebant pellem* via the "vertical" alliterated (and assonating) sequence . . . *pubis* / . . . *pellem* / . . . *puppi* / . . . *palmis*.[11]

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9 As pointed out to me by Elaine Fantham, the vertical *p*-pattern noted here can be seen as a kind of continuation or development of the directly preceding vertical assonating sequence *robora, avertere, decurrere, aequora* in the same lines.

10 Above, note 6, 123 and 127.

11 To the best of my knowledge, the only previous notice of this extraordinary sequence is that of J. Ferguson, which came to my attention after the above was written. Ferguson observes: "Seven of the first eight lines (counting *per-undas* as one word) end with a word which begins with *p* : I think that this represents the plop of the ship and the regular surge of the waves" (*Catullus* [Lawrence 1985] 197). Beyond the arithmetical slip (the correct count would be "six of the first seven lines"), the metaphorical interpretation is gratuitous; on this point see the comments on so-called "sound symbolism" in B. Vine, review of Raymond Chapman, *The Treatment of Sounds in Language and Literature* (Oxford 1984), *Language* 61 (1985) 934-35 and in Olga T. Yokoyama and B. Vine, "Sound patterns in the *Slovo o polku Igoreve*: Comparative and theoretical perspectives on Old Russian poetics," *American Contributions to the Tenth International Congress of Slavists: Literature*, ed. by Jane Gary Harris (Columbus 1988) 425-26.

III Catullus 16 and 42

The "vertical" technique seen in 64.4-7 is neither isolated, nor an insignificant and fortuitous aberration, but rather a real feature of Catullus' style. This is shown by the polymetric poems, where similarly concentrated configurations of line-final (and also line-initial) phonetic repetitions based on *p-* (often linked with other labials) appear with some frequency. In this section I examine two such cases in some detail; several others will be adduced more briefly in §4.

Consider first the following line-final sequences from poem 16:

5)

putastis	3
parum pudicum	4
pium poetam	5
. . . . .	
parum pudici	8
possunt	9
pilosis	10

Note first that the more compressed format of the hendecasyllabic meter renders such patterns more phonetically prominent, if anything, than those separated (as in poem 64) by twelve or thirteen syllables. But, beyond this general observation about the polymetric poems, one can be much more specific about the phonetic structure of poem 16. Given the almost identical phrases *parum pudicum* and *parum pudici* (in lines 4 and 8), it is perhaps not surprising that the patterns in (5) are actually embedded within a more intricate network of repetitions, some of which can be highlighted as in (6):

6)

Pedicabo ego vos et irrumabo,		1
Aureli pathice		3
quod sunt **molliculi**, parum pudicum		4
salem ac leporem	l/l/r	7
si sunt **molliculi** ac parum pudici,	ll/l/r	8
pruriat incitare possunt,	r/r/r	9
pueris ... his pilosis	r/l; -īs/-īs/-īs	10
duros ... movere lumbos.	r/r/l; -ōs/-ōs	11
vos ... milia multa basiorum	l/l/r; vōs	12
male me marem putatis?	l/r	13
Pedicabo ego vos et irrumabo.	rr; vōs	14

This is, to begin with, one of several similar poems in which the first and last lines are identical; note further that lines 4 and 8 are virtually identical, repeating not only the phrase with *p-*, but also the marked diminutive *molliculi*, again with an initial labial. In fact, one could say that not only the initial *p-* of the opening *Pedicabo* but also its *-b-* , together with the two labials of the parallel *irrumabo*, set the key, as it were, for the line-final sequences throughout the poem, nearly all of which involve labials. In addition to the two sets of word-initial "vertical" *p*-repetitions already indicated in (5), note the concentration of *m*'s and *b*'s, as seen particularly in lines 8-14. Even the liquids of *irrumabo* and *molliculi* (not to mention the addressees

Aurelius and *Furius*, as well as certain key words like *salem* and *leporem*) enter the fabric of the poem via the rather dense concentration of *r*'s and *l*'s also noted in (6). Considered in these phonetic terms (and partly also semantic terms, in that the phonetic repetitions link certain key words and concepts), Catullus' repetition of 16.1 as the last line of the poem is no mere mechanical device, but emerges as the culmination of an almost inevitable artistic progression.

In poem 42, we find again a considerable element of "vertical" *p*-repetitions, although the distribution within the line is somewhat freer than in 16:

7)						
		putat	...	turpis	put-/tu(r)p-	3
	pugillaria	...		pati potestis	pug-/pat-/pot-	5
	persequamur				per-	6
	turpe				tu(r)p-	8
		putida			pūt-	11
		putida			pūt-	12
			lutum lupanar		lut-/lup-	13
		perditius potes			per-/pot-	14
				putandum	put-	15
		potest			pot-	16
		putida			pūt-	19
		putida			pūt-	20
		proficimus	...	movetur	profic-/mov-	21
	mutanda ... modus				mūt-/mod-	22
		proficere	...	potestis	profic-/pot-	23
	pudica ... proba				pud-/prob-	24

Here again, the elements in (7) form an integral part of a complex pattern of repetition that involves an extended series of pun-like alterations, repeated lines used as refrains (with slight variations), and also patterns involving end-rhyme, as further indicated in (8):

8)		
	Adeste, hendecasyllabi, quot estis	1
	omnes undique, quotquot estis omnes.	2
	persequamur eam et reflagitemus.	6
	mimice ac moleste	8
	circumsistite eam et reflagitate,	10
	"moecha **putida**, redde codicillos	11
	redde, **putida** moecha, codicillos!"	12
	o lutum, lupanar	13
	ruborem	16
	ore [cf. 9 catuli **ore** Gallicani]	17
	conclamate iterum altiore voce	18
	"moecha **putida**, redde codicillos [= 11]	19
	redde, **putida** moecha, codicillos!" [= 12]	20
	"**pudica** et proba, redde codicillos."	24

I must emphasize that a more complete analysis of the poem (which deserves an investigation of its own, and for which space is not available here) would reveal a surprising number of interesting and effective details of phonetic organization, even though only a few are conventionally noted.[12] It will suffice for our purposes simply to observe that the entire phonetic structure of the poem, with its punning repetitions of *put-* and *pūt-*, *turp-*, *pat-*, *pot-*, *lut-*, *lup-*, serves as a kind of iconic framework for the main humorous point—the punchline—which is precisely the punning substitution of *pudīca* for *pūtida* in the vocative part of the refrain (whose purpose, incidentally, is to secure the return of Catullus' ***pugillaria***). With a final masterstroke, the very concept of substitution itself (the verbal manifestation or description, so to speak, of the idea of transformation inherent in punning) is integrated into the phonetic play, via the word ***mutanda*** (22 *mutanda est ratio*).[13]

Even though Herescu's concern with "assonance" in the strict sense of *rime vocalique* was much more limited than some of the patterns described above, he arrived at a similar conception of Catullus' use of sustained phonetic structuring in some poems, using poem 42 as an example:[14]

> Certaines parmi ses poésies offrent cet ornement sonore du commencement à la fin, presque sans interruption; et ceci ne se produit pas seulement dans des pièces plus courtes, où la réussite était plus facile ..., mais aussi dans des morceaux un peu plus longs, telle la pièce 42, où le défilé des assonances ... n'est interrompu que pour faire place au refrain ou à la répétition.

IV *Further Examples and Discussion*

As I have already indicated, these examples are not isolated, as evidenced by further instances like those in (9):

9) a	ponte		8
	per caputque pedesque		9
	putidaeque paludis		10
		(Catullus 17)	

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12 Thus e.g. Eduard Fraenkel ("Two poems of Catullus," *JRS* 51 [1961] 48) notes the *m*-alliteration in 42.8, the emphatic effect of the geminate in the repeated line-final *codicillos*, and the (otherwise much-discussed) use of *r* (the so-called *littera canina*), as in 42.16-17 *ruborem / ferreo canis exprimamus ore* .

13 The *semantic* importance of *mutanda* in this context is signaled by Offermann (above, note 2) 246 note 57.

14 Herescu (above, note 4) 141.

After my own analysis of poem 42 was written, I was gratified to find that Ferguson's interesting phonetic observations on the poem (above, note 11, 122) led to much the same conclusion regarding the importance of *p* ; following a detailed survey of various phonetic effects, including what Ferguson refers to as a technique of "exaggerated alliteration", he observes: "But the primary letter of this piece is *p* ; it is an explosive letter which expresses all the force of Catullus' feelings. He establishes it early in *pugillaria, si pati potestis / persequamur* (42.5-6); it is reinforced in the four-times-repeated *putida*, and in *perditius potes* (42.14). The result is that when we come to the climax of the poem we see that Catullus has changed his words without changing his tune. The meaning of the words [in the last line] is flattering; the abusive tone remains."

b	possunt		4
	parente		5
	parentis		6
	fricesque	-ēsque	22
	posses	-ēs	23
	beata Furi	-rī	24
	putare parvi	-āre -arvī	25
	precari	-ārī	26
	beatus #		27
		(Catullus 23)	
c	potest		21
	piissimi		22
	perdidistis omnia		23
		(Catullus 29)	
d	pessimus omnium poeta		5
	pessimus omnium poeta	[2 Marce Tulli	6
	optimus omnium patronus. #	4 Catullus]	7
		(Catullus 49)	
e	Pulcre convenit improbis cinaedis	[+ m/r/l throughout]	1
	...puellularum		9
	Pulcre convenit improbis cinaedis. #		10
		(Catullus 57)	

The material in (9) suggests that we have here something systematic about Catullus' phonetic technique. In addition to the prominent use of forms of *possum* and of more or less negative terms like *putidae paludis* (much as in 16 and 42), note also the more complex patterns in poem 23 involving liquids and end-rhymes, the identical first and last lines of 57 (again involving initial *p*-), and also the fact that three of these cases appear at the *ends* of poems (namely the ones marked with number signs), which may suggest a certain clausular orientation of this technique, as also, to some extent, in 16 and 42.

These contexts are almost all abusive in nature, and so it seems clear that their phonetic technique, with regard to this particular feature, has a different stylistic pedigree from the Ennian example discussed in §2. Perhaps the most suitable comparandum is the "invective" *p*-alliteration well-documented in rhetorical writing, and otherwise used by Catullus himself, as in the conventional Ciceronian cliché *pestem perniciemque* of 76.20.[15] But in view of the more complex patterning these cases show (involving such features as other labials, liquids, refrains, end-rhyme), the question is clearly not so simple, and warrants further study in terms of Catullus' entire palette of phonetic orchestration.

While some features (such as certain uses of *p*-) may be more or less restricted to invective contexts, others—such as the "vertical" deployment of

15 Cf. Cicero, *Cat.* 1.33, *Off.* 2.51, etc., and Marilyn B. Skinner, "Disease imagery in Catullus 76.17-26," *CP* 82 (1987) 231-32.

consonants in successive lines—are clearly more general. It has often been noted, for example, that the phonetic organization of poem 46 (*Iam ver egelidos*) is extraordinarily effective.[16] Much of this, I would claim, is due to the partly vertical patterning of the labial glide [w], which picks up the key word *ver* 'spring' from line 1, and reappears in a more traditional alliterated sequence in the last line, as indicated in (10):

(10) Iam ver egelidos refert tepores 1
volemus urbes 6
avet vagari 7
vigescunt 8
diversae varie viae reportant 10
[cf.: 10 reportant ~ 1 refert tepores]

(Catullus 46)

V *Conclusion*

Some readers of this essay may well feel that it is the analyst, and not the poet, who is phonetically obsessed. But the fundamental importance, for linguistic poetics, of what has come to be called "subliminal verbal patterning" no longer requires substantiation, either in general,[17] or with regard to Catullus.[18] To be sure, isolated algebraic descriptions of such patterning are of limited interest; they become meaningful only when they can be integrated with some part of the texture of a particular poem and/or with other features of a poet's technique. I have tried to show that the "vertical" patterning described above is not an illusion, but rather part and parcel of Catullus' characteristic (and partly, we should remember, experimental) lexical and phonetic technique. If this is so, the further investigation of these patterns cannot help but enhance our insight into Catullus as a poet, and therefore our appreciation and enjoyment of his art.[19]

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16 See especially Elder "Conscious and Subconscious," (1951) 120-21, and more recently Jean Granarolo, "Quelques composantes mélodiques de l'alexandrinisme catullien," *Euphrosyne* 12 (1983-84) 124-26.

17 See Roman Jakobson's 1970 paper, "Subliminal verbal patterning in poetry," in *Selected Writings III: Poetry of Grammar and Grammar of Poetry* (The Hague-Paris-New York 1981), as well as numerous other studies reprinted in Jakobson 1981.

18 See already Elder, "Conscious and Subconscious," 1951, and note David O. Ross' apposite comments on the question of Catullus' "conscious effort" in poetic composition (*Style and Tradition in Catullus* [Cambridge 1969] 7).

19 An earlier version of this paper was presented at the 120th Annual Meeting of the American Philological Association (Baltimore, MD; January, 1989).